

Digital Transformation — Module 05: Action —

Discussion Questions

20 questions on process automation, RPA, and the rigidity-agility trade-off.

1. How does Tesla's manufacturing experience illustrate the limits of extreme automation?
2. What makes a process a good candidate for automation? What makes it a bad candidate?
3. How does the rigidity-agility trade-off shape the design of automated workflows?
4. When should an organization use RPA (simple, rule-based) versus intelligent automation (AI-based)?
5. How does process automation change the nature of remaining human work?
6. What organizational resistance to automation is legitimate versus based on fear?
7. When automation fails (system outage, edge case), how should organizations handle the fallback to human processes?
8. How do you measure the ROI of process automation beyond simple cost savings?
9. Compare the automation strategies appropriate for a startup versus a mature enterprise.
10. How should organizations retrain workers whose jobs are being automated?
11. Identify three processes in your organization that are candidates for automation. For each, assess readiness.
12. Map the automation spectrum in your organization: what is manual, assisted, RPA, intelligent, or autonomous?
13. Design an automation pilot for one high-impact process. Include success criteria and risk mitigation.
14. What processes in your organization should NOT be automated? Why?
15. How do regulatory requirements affect automation decisions in your industry?
16. Design a "human-in-the-loop" automated process that combines automation efficiency with human oversight.
17. Compare the total cost of ownership of an automated system versus a human-operated process over 5 years.
18. How does infrastructure-as-code change the agility of automated systems?

19. When should an organization automate internally versus outsource to a service provider?
20. Design an automation roadmap for your department, prioritizing by impact and implementation difficulty.